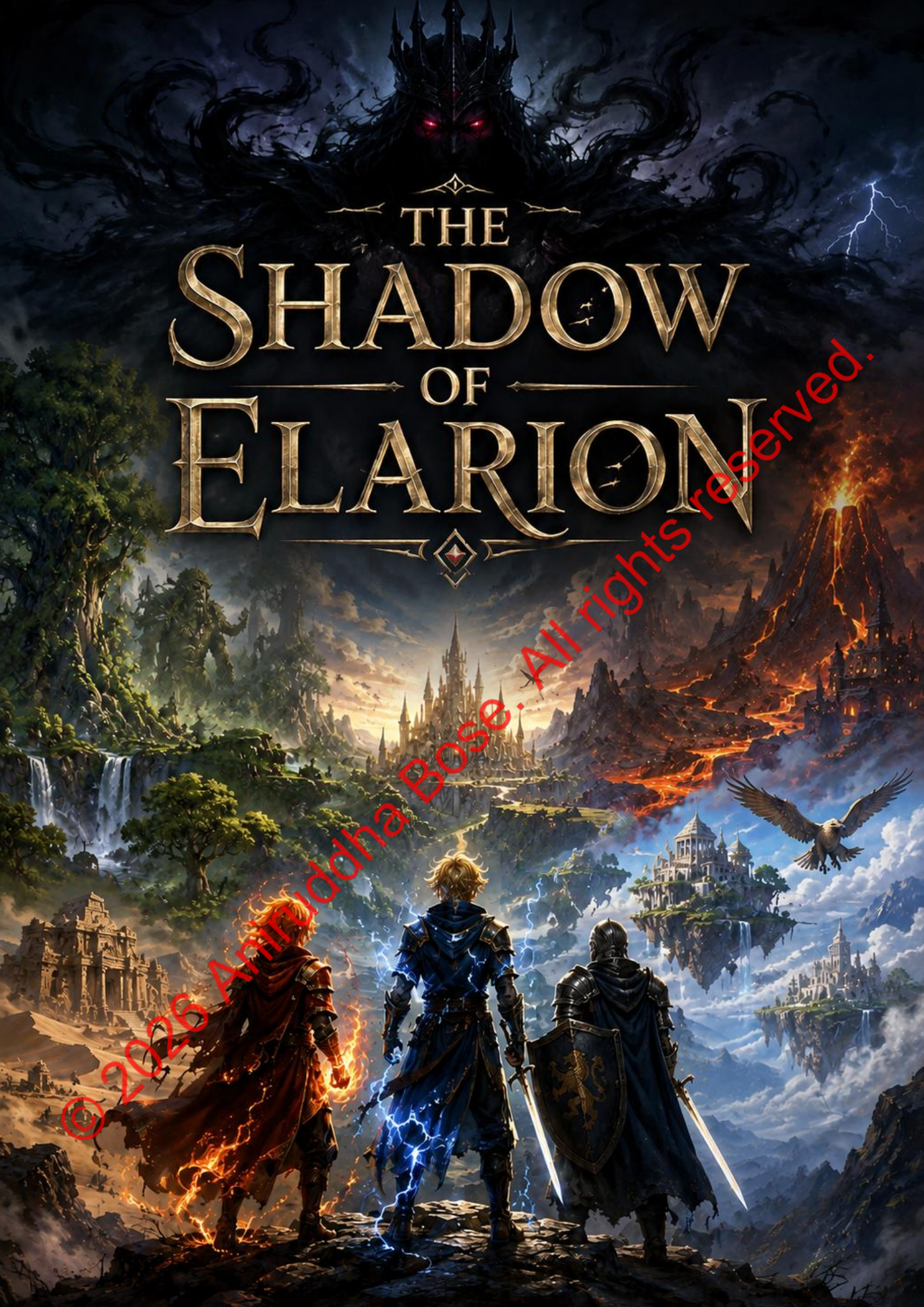


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The Shadow of Elarion

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Chapter I: The Beginning

Ring! Ring! Ring!

I jumped out of bed. It was Saturday, and I was supposed to meet Rowan. After yawning and stretching my arms and legs for a bit, I rushed to brush my teeth and get dressed. I really didn't want to be late because Rowan said he found a really old video game cartridge while clearing out his attic a few days ago, and he wanted us to try it out together. I hurriedly gobbled down my breakfast, then I rushed out of the house and down the street to Rowan's house. He was waiting with a warm smile, probably as excited as me to try out the game.

Once we went inside, Rowan fetched the cartridge and inserted it into his Nintendo Switch. The cartridge read, "Realms of Elarion" in faded gold lettering—certainly not any game we'd heard of. Once it started, it asked us to choose a character. There were five different characters with different elemental abilities—Ignis, Glacius, Zephyr, Volt and Terra. Rowan said, "I'll go with Ignis. His fire abilities are going to be really fun to use." I chose Volt, because his lightning abilities sounded like they were going to be really helpful.

Then, the walls started shaking. A faint blue glow started coming from the console, which then grew into a shimmering blue portal. It was pulling us in, and the last thing I remember was our desperate attempts to hold on to something to avoid getting sucked in.

Then everything went black.

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Chapter II: Entry into Elarion

When I woke up, the first thing I noticed was that we were no longer in Rowan's room. The two of us were lying on a flat grassy meadow, with bright green grass lit by the shining sun in the bright, blue, clear sky. Such beauty was nowhere to be seen in the urban jungle we lived in, where the sky would be blocked by towering skylines. We were still contemplating where we were and how we got here, when a knight clad in shining steel armour came towards us. We closed our eyes, preparing for the worst, but it never came. The knight said, "Greetings, brave heroes! You have arrived to save Elarion, just as the prophecy foretold!" We were confused. "What is Elarion?" I asked.

"Elarion is our world, the world of five realms," said the knight. "And I am Sir Cedric, captain of the Royal Guard," he added. Then it clicked. The game is real. We got pulled into it to save this world. "But from who?" I asked. "The Shadow King," Sir Cedric replied, "the ancient evil that wants to plunge our world into eternal shadow."

He waved and suddenly a grand golden chariot materialized out of thin air. "Come, the King and Queen wish to see you immediately." Rowan and I climbed on, excited to know more about the adventure which we had just been plunged into.

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Chapter III: The King and Queen

The chariot took off into the skies and within half an hour, we had arrived over a huge, sprawling city full of shining golden towers, with a grand, enormous palace at the center of it all. “This is Lumoria,” said Sir Cedric, “it is our capital, the home of the King and Queen of Elarion.” “Wow!” Rowan and I exclaimed at the same time.

Soon, we landed at the palace. As we went inside, we were amazed by its interior. There were crystal chandeliers illuminating the vast hallways, and many rooms, each serving a different purpose. There was a kitchen with the smell of fresh bread wafting from it, and an armoury with gleaming steel suits. When we arrived at the throne room, the King and Queen welcomed us in. We bowed in respect, then listened to what they were saying.

The King said, “You have been summoned to save Elarion. An ancient evil, the Shadow King, has awakened after centuries of sleep. He wants to conquer all the five realms and plunge them into eternal darkness. You must brave the realms and defeat him in the Shadow Stronghold before he can achieve his goal. To do this, each of you have been given powers to assist you. Your powers shall now be activated.”

Then, he sprinkled a bit of sparkling magic dust on us. Suddenly, we transformed. I became a warrior with yellow hair and electricity sparking all around me, while Rowan became a warrior with blazing orange hair and fire embers circling him. We had transformed into our chosen characters—Volt and Ignis.

“Long ago, a legendary weapon called the Blade of Dawn was used to defeat the Shadow King. While the Shadow King was sealed away, the weapon was shattered into five shards hidden across the realms. You must travel to each of the realms and collect the shards. The shards are guarded by fearsome guardians, who have been corrupted by the Shadow King’s influence. In order to retrieve the shards, you will have to defeat these guardians. Then, you can use the Blade of Dawn to vanquish the Shadow King in Umbros. Sir Cedric will be your guide,” said the King.

“We will give you a map to navigate your way through Elarion, and a small bag to store the shards,” the Queen said, handing us the two objects.

Sir Cedric said, “Come, let us set out on our adventure!”

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Chapter IV: The Forest Realm

We hopped on our magic carriage and soon enough, we reached Verdantia, the Forest Realm. It was a thick, dense jungle, with lush green trees towering above our heads. Occasionally, the chirp of a bird or the shriek of a monkey could be heard. Then, we took out our map and inspected it. “The shard is this way,” Sir Cedric said, pointing to our right.

A few minutes after we started walking, we saw an entire group of monkeys coming at us from the trees. They were shrieking loudly, pulling on our hair and clothes. We tried to run, but the monkeys kept chasing us relentlessly. “Huh. This isn’t normal. We don’t have any food,” Rowan said. “I know, but right now we need to get rid of them,” I shouted to make myself heard among the noisy shrieks all around us. “Use your abilities,” Sir Cedric urged.

I tried to summon lightning, but all I got were sparks coming from my hand. Sir Cedric shouted, “Focus your mind. Put all your will into it!” I closed my eyes and focused hard on summoning lightning. Nothing happened. Then, as the monkeys pulled me left and right, and started scratching me, it happened. I heard a crackling sound, followed by blue zigzags of lightning coming from my hand. The monkeys ran away, shrieking in terror as they went. “That was so cool!” Rowan exclaimed, “I hope I get to do that soon.”

Well, he did get his chance. After an hour more of trekking through the forest (and getting a few mosquito bites along the way), we arrived at a clearing. The shard we were looking for was hovering on top of a pedestal covered with moss and vines. We were about to reach for it, when we heard a giant thud behind us, followed by a loud roar. A giant ape, about five times taller than us, came into the clearing, his eyes swirling with black wisps of shadow as he pounded his chest. “That is Gorath the Great Ape,” Sir Cedric whispered to us, “the guardian of Verdantia.”

The ape uprooted a tree and threw it at us, making all three of us duck. Rowan closed his eyes and focused hard, trying to create fire. Small embers drifted from his hand but no fire. Then, just as Gorath threw another tree at us, a giant wall of fire emerged from his hand, burning the tree to ashes. I then summoned lightning upon Gorath, but he dodged it with ease. “We need a distraction,” I said. “On it,” said Rowan. He started throwing fireballs at Gorath, making him roar in pain and retaliate by throwing more trees at us, while I channelled all my focus into summoning more lightning. Finally, I brought a second lightning strike upon the ape, making him roar in pain before falling to the ground with smoke rising from the spot where my lightning struck him. The darkness slowly drifted away from Gorath's eyes. He opened them and let out a gentle grunt, then slowly got up and disappeared into the forest. The corruption was gone.

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“We did it!” all of us exclaimed, feeling proud that we had taken on this giant ape and removed the Shadow King’s corruption. Rowan and I approached the shard cautiously, checking every step to make sure there were no traps. Then, when we collected the shard, it pulsed with a soft glow as we stored it in our bag. Sir Cedric summoned the magic carriage, and we climbed onto it, ready to go to the next realm.

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Chapter V: A Land of Dunes

Solkaris was a vast scorching desert. We could see a village from the sky and we landed there. Almost immediately, we knew something was wrong. We could see a few broken houses, and a silence hung over the place. We went to one of the villagers and asked, “What has happened to your village?”

He said, “Our guardian, Duneguard, has been corrupted by the influence of the Shadow King. He is wreaking havoc upon the villages, trampling houses and stealing food in the night. I see that you are warriors. Would you be able to help us?” “Of course,” I replied, “anyway, we have come here on the King and Queen’s orders to retrieve the shards.” “Well, if you want to fight him, he was last seen going that way,” the villager said, pointing to the east. Looking at our map, we said, “There’s supposed to be an ancient temple there, where the shard is supposed to be protected. That’s probably where he went.” We set off into the vast expanse of dunes to find Duneguard and defeat him.

Indeed, after a gruelling journey across the desert, we reached an ancient temple, of which some parts were crumbling. When we entered, we saw massive, cracked sandstone pillars stretching to the ceiling, with ancient carvings on them. It was really dark, as the old torches lining the pillars had long burnt out. “I could give us some light,” Rowan volunteered. He summoned flames in his hand and then threw them at the torches, lighting them ablaze almost immediately. “Thanks, Rowan,” I said, smiling. Just as we were continuing on, the floor gave way.

We fell into a pit with hundreds of scorpions at the sides, scuttling closer and closer to us. “Guys, trouble incoming!” I shouted urgently. Rowan and I tried to kill the scorpions using our abilities but as we killed them, more came from the corners. Suddenly, Sir Cedric spotted four buttons with different symbols on them—a sun, a moon, a monument and a scorpion. Below the text there was something written in an unknown language. Sir Cedric seemed to understand it though. “It says ‘Press the buttons in the order of a desert day’,” he said. We were stumped. We already knew that the moon would be after the sun, because night starts after the day ends, but what about the monument and the scorpion? Those made no sense.

Suddenly it clicked. Workers do a lot of work to build a monument. And when do they do work? During the day, after the sun rises! And scorpions usually come out at dusk, just before the moon rises and night begins! “I figured it out,” I shouted, “the order is Sun, Monument, Scorpions, Moon!” “Press the buttons, quickly, before we die to these scorpions,” I added. Sir Cedric pressed the buttons, and immediately, a door opened in front of us. We ran for our lives, the scorpions chasing relentlessly. After we passed through the door, Sir Cedric quickly pulled a lever to close it.

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“Phew! That was close,” I said. We all breathed a sigh of relief, then continued walking, watching every step as we went. Luckily, there were no more traps. Soon, we arrived at an enormous colosseum, with the shard hovering on a pedestal in the center. Duneguard was standing in front of it, his eyes clouded in shadow.

The moment he saw us, he rushed towards us. Each of his stomps shook the ground, sometimes so strongly that we were knocked back. I summoned a lightning bolt on him, but he remained mostly unscathed apart from a small smouldering spot at the top of his head. I might have also made him more angry, because he picked up a nearby boulder and hurled it at us. We ran out of its way, and saw the boulder crash into the wall. Rowan showered him with fireballs, but it was futile. It made sense, because Duneguard was a golem made of sandstone, not a being with flesh and bones.

Suddenly, I had an idea. “Rowan,” I shouted, “we have to work together!” Rowan nodded, knowing what we had to do. I summoned bolt after bolt upon Duneguard, while Rowan showered him with fireballs. When he retaliated by throwing boulders, we dodged them. Slowly but surely, we could see the boss disintegrating. The edges of his body crumbled into small rocks. We were starting to feel dizzy. “Just...some....more...” I mumbled. I channelled all my energy and summoned a huge lightning ray. I say ray, because it looked more like a huge laser cannon firing from the sky than lightning. Duneguard’s body cracked, and he fell to the ground with a huge shockwave. We were knocked back, and then I passed out.

The first thing I saw when I woke up was Sir Cedric and Rowan standing over me with worried expressions. “Are you okay?” they asked when I woke up. “Yeah... what happened?” I asked. Sir Cedric explained, “I think it’s because of the energy you channelled. After you brought that final lightning strike upon Duneguard, you fainted. Duneguard woke up after a while, rid of the Shadow King’s corruption. We collected the shard and put it in the bag.” “Did Rowan faint as well?” I asked. “No, although he was very dizzy for some time,” Sir Cedric replied. “Okay,” I said, getting up, “We have work to do! Let’s head to Pyraxis!”

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Chapter VI: The Fires of Pyraxis

When we landed in Pyraxis, we saw a barren, fiery wasteland. Lava rivers flowed, and the air was full of suffocating smoke. The ground was made almost entirely of basalt. In the distance, we could see the burnt remains of a village. “How could there be anyone living here?” I thought to myself. As if reading my mind, Sir Cedric said, “This is the home of the dwarves, renowned throughout Elarion for their skilled craftsmanship.” “If there are any surviving villages,” Sir Cedric said, looking worriedly at the burnt village, “the dwarves can forge us some weapons to fight the Fire Dragon, the guardian of this realm.”

We spent hours wandering through the realm. Every time we saw a village, our hearts leapt in joy, then we went closer only to see that it was burnt to ashes. Finally, we saw an intact village, fortified by giant basalt walls. As we went closer towards it, we met a bearded man about half our height carrying a pickaxe. “Aye lads, what ye doin’ out ‘ere? Haven’t ye heard? Our guardian, the Fire Dragon, has gon’ rogue! The beast’s been terrorizin’ our settlements fer weeks now!” “We’re here to fight the beast,” I said, “Your dragon’s been corrupted by the Shadow King.”

“By my beard! The Shadow King, ye say? He’s been asleepin’ for centuries!” the dwarf exclaimed. “Well, he’s woken up again, and he’s planning to shroud all the realms in eternal darkness,” I said, “We’re heroes sent by the King and Queen.” “Bah! What kind o’ beard-brained nonsense is that? We sent some o’ them heroes down the tunnels, but not one o’ ‘em ever came back! That dragon’ll roast ye alive!” the dwarf said. “Well, we’ve come this far. We sure aren’t turning back now,” I said. “Fine,” he sighed. “But if yer thinkin’ o’ fightin’ our dragon, ye’re gonna need yerselves some proper weapons. Come with me, I’ll take ye to me village!” “Okay,” we agreed.

The dwarf led us towards a gate at the center of the wall. He shouted, “Guards! It’s me, Korik! I’ve some visitors with me. Open the gates an’ let us in!” “On it!” shouted a distant voice. Then, the gate opened, creaking as it went. Korik led us through the bustling village, until we reached a massive stone building carved into the side of a volcano. “This be the forge of Grondar Ironforge, the bes’ blacksmith in Pyraxis!”

We knocked on the door and waited. Soon, we met a stocky, bearded dwarf, a bit larger than Korik. We immediately knew he was Grondar. He wore a dark red work shirt with a dirty, leather blacksmith apron. “Aye, Grondar! These ‘ere lads need some weapons. They wantin’ to fight the dragon!” Korik said. Grondar eyed us suspiciously for a while, then led us into the building. I immediately felt beads of sweat trickling down my forehead. The forge glowed with an orange-red light, sparks dancing all around it. We saw a giant anvil battered and worn down by hammer marks. A large collection of weapons lined the walls, including sharp swords, large, heavy axes and suits of thick iron armour. “I’ll do it for ye,” said Grondar, “but I’m gon’ need somethin’ in return.”

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“We’re saving Elarion from the clutches of the Shadow King. Isn’t that enough?” I tried to argue. “Nay. We ask fer… that,” Grondar said, pointing at the bag. “No way,” I said, “that’s the fragments of the Blade of Dawn. We need it to defeat the Shadow King.” “Do ye know where that Blade of Dawn was made? It was forged in the fires of us dwarves, thousands of years ago, an’ it be our greatest creation. It’s rightfully ours. Now, give the sword to us an’ I’ll make whatever weapons ye need!”

“But we need it to defeat the Shadow King! The King and Queen entrusted us with this quest. We cannot simply hand it over to you!” I argued. “Aye. That be true,” he said, stroking his beard in thought, “alright, we’ll let ye do yer quest. But after that’s done an’ over with, ye have to hand that sword over. I’m gon’ send Korik with ye so ye don’t double-cross us.” “Okay,” we agreed in unison, “now can we have weapons to fight the dragon?”

“I’ll make me best work for ye!” Grondar said. He opened a stone valve, and molten lava flowed into the forge. He tossed some chunks of crimson ore into the furnace. “This be Emberstone,” he said, “the finest metal in all o’ Pyraxis.” Once the metal glowed white hot, he placed it upon the anvil and struck it repeatedly with his hammer, sending sparks flying across the room, until he had fashioned it into a sword. “There ye go, lads. Now time to make some more o’ this.”

Once we were all geared up with our new weapons, Korik led us into the tunnels. He was not too happy about it, and expressed his discontent every few minutes by muttering, “All o’ us are gonna die,” or “This is the mos’ rock-headed nonsense I’ve ever seen!” Suddenly, creatures jumped at us out of nowhere. They looked like reddish-brown lizards. “Volcanic salamanders,” Korik said, “had to deal with ‘em pesky rascals every now and then in the mines.” We slashed at them with our new swords until they were all dead. “We need to watch our step from now on,” I cautioned.

Finally, after hours of navigating the tunnels, we tumbled into a giant cave. In the center was a basalt pedestal with a shard hovering above it, just like the other realms, but here there were streams of lava flowing through the cracks in the rock. A dragon circled the shard, his eyes swirling with black, inky darkness. He roared at us and let out a jet of fire. We had to duck to avoid getting burnt. Rowan tried launching fireballs at him, but it was ineffective. Well, it made sense. A fire dragon is going to be immune to fire, right? We slashed at the dragon with our swords, making a few cuts in its thick skin. I summoned lightning upon the dragon, and after that he retaliated by letting out another burst of fire.

Suddenly, I had an idea. “Guys, we’ll distract the dragon while Sir Cedric can stab it with his sword!” Sir Cedric nodded to say yes. Rowan launched fireballs at the dragon, while I shot beams of lightning at him. Korik hollered to grab the dragon’s attention. Meanwhile, Sir Cedric rushed towards the dragon and dealt the final blow, driving his sword deep into the dragon’s body. The dragon let out a roar, before finally collapsing to the ground.

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All of us breathed a sigh of relief. We had defeated the Fire Dragon. The black wisps in his eyes disappeared. The Fire Dragon slowly woke up and looked at us calmly, before spreading his enormous wings. With one final roar, he soared out of the cave.

Cautiously, we went towards the pedestal and collected the shard. As we put it into our bag, Sir Cedric summoned the magic carriage. We eagerly climbed onto it, ready to go to Celestara, the Sky Realm.

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Chapter VII: Above the Clouds

As we went higher and higher up, large floating islands slowly came into view. Once we landed, we saw a beautiful scene. Crystal-clear, turquoise water poured from large, white marble fountains. There were buildings made of white marble and held up by tall, circular pillars with elaborate carvings on them. We saw winged people flying from one island to another. “Who are they?” asked Rowan. “They, my friends, are Avians. They are the residents of Celestara. They were once men, long ago, but they have been granted the boon of flight. It is they who now inhabit these islands.”

Suddenly, a deafening screech echoed across the sky, and a giant shadow passed over the city. The Avians started squawking and fleeing to their homes. When we looked up, we saw a giant eagle, its wings so large that they were almost entirely blocking out the sun. Sir Cedric said, “This is Tempestwing, the Great Roc. He is the guardian of the skies.” Just like all the other guardians we had encountered, his eyes swirled with black shadow.

He squawked loudly before diving at us and grabbing me with his claws. “Aah! Help!” I shouted desperately as the roc carried me off into the sky. Rowan shot a fireball that hit the roc’s right wing, causing him to lose his grip on me. I plummeted down and down, thinking I would die that day, when an Avian grabbed me and brought me up to safety. I thanked him, and we continued fighting the roc. I summoned lightning upon him, forcing him to veer away from us.

The roc landed on a floating island. Then, he flapped his wings and unleashed a gust of wind, knocking all of us off our feet. Rowan threw fireballs at him, knocking him back. But he only grew angrier. Dark clouds gathered over the realm, then lightning started striking our island. We couldn’t stand still now, or we would be struck by lightning and would surely be dead. I aimed lightning bolts at the roc, but aiming was proving to be hard while constantly dodging the lightning. He screeched and started flying towards us, and this was our chance. Rowan summoned a giant wall of fire that burned the roc’s feathers, making him crash down to the ground.

The black wisps disappeared from his eyes. On his chest, we saw a gold medallion with the glowing shard at the center of it. Slowly, the roc rose. He squawked, and the shard rose from his medallion and dropped into my hands. “I think he’s giving us the shard,” I said.

“Now, the Blade of Dawn can be reforged,” said Sir Cedric. We took all the shards from our bag and arranged them side by side. Suddenly, the shards started glowing brightly as they fused to each other and let out a blinding light. Once the light faded, we saw a shining sword, its gold hilt decorated with precious stones.

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“Now,” Sir Cedric said, growing serious, “in order to reach Umbros, we must cross the Black Sea. It is said to be cursed, the place where all manner of corrupted creatures reside.” We gulped. “We cannot fly over the Black Sea, or the storms will surely destroy us,” said Sir Cedric, “we must sail through it.”

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Chapter VIII: Voyage into Darkness

The Avians had a giant sky lift that lowered us to the surface. Then, we had to walk for almost two days to get to Lastlight Harbour, the last settlement before the Black Sea. There, Korik helped us bargain with the sailors, and we bought the sturdiest ship available, The Pathfinder. “Here she goes,” said Sir Cedric as we set sail from the harbour. We could see the vast, dark expanse of the Black Sea, and it was evident how it got its name. Huge, black storm clouds covered the sky, blocking all sunlight from reaching the water. Thick, dense fog hung above the water, making it hard to see far. I shuddered at the thought of what horrors might be lurking in the depths.

As The Pathfinder sailed on, we saw a silhouette of a ship in the distance. As it came into view, we saw an ancient, deserted vessel with torn sails, a broken mast and no lights. Suddenly, ghostly figures appeared on the deck. “Turn back now...while you can...” they said, their voices echoing, “you will meet the same fate as us if you go any further...” We braced ourselves for an attack, but none came. The ship simply disappeared back into the fog.

A few more hours went by. Occasionally, huge waves would shake the ship, but nothing more. Then, we saw glistening black scales coming out of the water. A massive sea serpent emerged, its teeth bared and its eyes engulfed with black, inky darkness. We sheathed our swords, and slashed at the serpent. I summoned lightning upon the serpent, knocking it back a bit. The serpent retaliated by smashing its tail into our ship, creating a huge hole. We knew we didn’t have long before The Pathfinder sank into the sea. “Sail on,” I shouted desperately to Sir Cedric. He sailed as fast as he could. Rowan and I kept using our abilities to knock the serpent back. Soon, it descended back into the depths.

The water was almost up to the deck when we reached Umbros. It was a dark island with a jet-black obsidian fortress in the center. Huge black clouds loomed above it, blocking all sunlight from reaching the island.

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Chapter IX: A Shadowy Wasteland

There were tall cliffs separating us from the stronghold. We walked around the island to find the shortest way up. Then, as we climbed to the top, dozens of dark figures came into view. They were clad in suits of armour, and their eyes glowed red with malice. As soon as they saw us, they rushed towards us with their swords. “Shadow Soldiers,” Sir Cedric muttered, “good, valiant knights like me, corrupted to do the Shadow King’s bidding.” Rowan and I used our powers against them. They were knocked back, but not killed.

We sheathed the Blade of Dawn, and used it to slash at the Shadow Soldiers. It was working! One by one, they collapsed into empty armour suits and fell to the ground with a blinding explosion of light. Soon, we had cleared the entire lot, with a few injuries here and there, but mostly we remained unscathed. We cautiously ventured into the Shadow Stronghold. There were Shadow Soldiers patrolling every nook and cranny of the castle, so we had to remain as quiet as a mouse. Whenever a soldier came close to us, we hid in one of many dusty closets that lined the hallways. Cobwebs hung from the cracked, cold stone walls, adding to the gloomy atmosphere.

Finally, after a while, we reached a large hall with a black, obsidian throne. Sitting on it was the Shadow King himself. His eyes glowed red, just like the Shadow Soldiers, and he had a black crown on top of his head. “Ah, finally. Submission,” the Shadow King said. “Bow before me, peasants,” he spat. “We’re not peasants,” I said, “and we haven’t come here to submit. We’re the mighty heroes of Elarion, heroes who have come to put an end to your sinister plans.” “Oh…” the Shadow King mocked, “you really think you can defeat me?” “Maybe not,” Sir Cedric said, sheathing the Blade of Dawn, “but we’ll die trying.”

“Bah! If ye really think ye can rule Elarion, then quit yer yappin’ and fight like a man!” Korik shouted. “Alright, puny dwarf,” the Shadow King said, “but you’ll regret it pretty soon.” Suddenly, black ropes emerged from the ground and wrapped us from head to toe. “Rowan!” I shouted. Rowan summoned fire and burnt the ropes binding us. “When did you puny humans get powers?” the Shadow King mocked.

“Well, you won’t be able to kill me if you can’t find me,” the Shadow King taunted as three clones of him appeared beside him. We slashed at them with our swords, but as one clone collapsed, another took its place. Frustrated, I summoned bolts of lightning on top of all the clones at the same time, and they all disappeared except for the original Shadow King, who was just knocked back.

“Hahaha,” the Shadow King laughed, “you really thought that was all I had?” He engulfed the entire room in darkness. We could barely see each other. “I have one last trick up my sleeve,” he said. “The Eclipse Beam. Once I fire it, you all will join the ranks

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of my shadow army." "Never!" Korik spat. A pulse started coming from his crown. He was charging the Eclipse Beam. We sheathed the Blade of Dawn, then nodded to each other. We charged at the Shadow King, just as the Eclipse Beam fired.

We thought we had lost. But the Blade of Dawn released its own beam of light, and the two beams were stuck in an epic battle of their own. The light beam was slowly overcoming the Eclipse Beam. Then, the Blade began cracking. Sir Cedric realized what was happening. "It's using all its power! It's going to be destroyed!" he exclaimed. "Guess there ain't gonna be no sword left fer me to take back home," Korik muttered. Then, the Blade let out a blinding explosion of light, so big that it spread across the entirety of Umbros and the Black Sea.

When the light faded, the Shadow King was gone. The dark clouds had parted and the sun shone brightly upon the land. All the Shadow Soldiers had collapsed into piles of empty armour suits. We had defeated the Shadow King and saved Elarion.

Sir Cedric waved his hand and the magic carriage materialized. We all climbed back into the carriage, ready to go back home.

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Chapter X: Back Where It Began

The moment we arrived back at Lumoria, cheers erupted throughout the streets. “They’re back!” a watchman shouted, “Elarion is saved!” Bells rang in celebration, and flower petals rained from the rooftops. As we landed at the castle, the King and Queen welcomed us.

“You have defeated the Shadow King and saved this world,” the King said, “all of Elarion owes you a debt that can never be repaid.” “To honour your courage, we will place your names in the Hall of Heroes,” the Queen said. “But tell me, who is this dwarf?” the King asked, looking at Korik. “Oh, he’s Korik. We met him at Pyraxis. He came with us because the dwarves wanted the Blade of Dawn returned to them, as their kind had first forged it. Or at least, that’s what they said. Anyway, now they can’t get the sword because there is no sword left,” I said. “Aye. It was a fine blade,” Korik said sadly.

“Why? What happened?” the Queen asked, worried. “The Blade of Dawn used all its power to defeat the Shadow King,” Sir Cedric explained. “Then it has fulfilled its purpose,” the King said. The Queen gave us medals. “This is an award recognizing your bravery,” she said.

“Now, it is time for all of you to go back home,” she said. The Queen waved her hand and an orange portal appeared. “Korik, this is a gateway back to your home, Pyraxis,” she said. Korik thanked her and went through the portal. Then she waved her hand again and this time, a shimmering blue portal appeared. “Heroes,” she said, looking at Rowan and me, “this is a gateway back to the world from which you came.” “Farewell, Elarion,” we said. We thanked the King and Queen and went through the portal.

Suddenly, we were back in our room, just as we had left it. We were wearing our normal clothes. “Whoa,” said Rowan, “that was really exciting!” “And scary,” I said. “I’m never going to look at video games the same again,” Rowan said, sighing.

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